bemused grin, often seems uncomfortable with the trappings of state—as if he would much rather be eating falafel and holding court in a streetside cafe.

The Rivlin family traces its roots to Lithuania, but his ancestors moved to Jerusalem more than two centuries ago, when it was still an Ottoman territory. His biography, somewhat unique among Israeli politicians, has done much to shape his worldview. Many of his colleagues speak of Jerusalem as a symbol, a collection of holy places and old stones. Rivlin is one of the few who imbues it with life, reminiscing about his time in the Scouts, or his competition with childhood friends to collect autographs at the Knesset. “You could trade six Menachem Begins for a David Ben-Gurion,” he joked. His father Yosef, a scholar of Semitic languages, translated the Qur’an and the *One Thousand and One Nights* into Hebrew. Rivlin himself speaks fluent Arabic (though he occasionally makes self-effacing jokes about his Hebrew accent). He hails from the political right, yet his closest friend in the Knesset was Ahmad Tibi, an Arab nationalist who served as an adviser to Yasser Arafat.

Rivlin has a reputation in the Knesset for niceness and decency—adjectives not often deployed in Israel’s raucous parliament. In many ways, his politics could be described as classical liberalism: he believes in civil liberties and individual freedoms, and as the Knesset speaker, he often blocked legislation that infringed upon those rights. In 2011 he publicly opposed the “Boycott Law”, which imposed civil penalties on Israelis who supported boycotts against their country. “Woe betide the Jewish democratic state that turns freedom of expression into a civil offense,” he wrote in a *Ha’aretz* op-ed. “[The law] threatens to catapult us into an era in which gagging people becomes accepted legal practice.”[9] He denounced efforts to remove Arab MK Hanin Zoabi from the parliament after she joined a Turkish aid flotilla to Gaza, as well as a law that allowed Israel to detain refugees indefinitely. When the Knesset debated a bill designed to push the small Arab parties out of the Knesset, Rivlin was the sole dissenting vote from Likud. He loudly condemned a ruling from a group of municipal rabbis that urged landlords not to rent apartments to Arabs, saying it “shamed the Jewish people.”

“I blocked the passage of several laws that the prime minister would have had much difficulty explaining to the world,” he said in a 2013 interview with Channel 10.[10]